

Vinegar Instead of Tomato Paste: A Turkish Kitchen Tries Filipino Adobo

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The ingredient list gave the trip away before I'd even started cooking. At the Asian grocery store near campus, I filled a basket with things no Turkish kitchen keeps on hand: cane vinegar distilled from sugarcane (*Saccharum officinarum*), a bottle of oyster sauce, dried bihon rice noodles, and a bag of bay leaves (*Laurus nobilis*) I already had at home but had never once used in a slow-simmered meat dish. My family and I picked chicken adobo, garlic rice, and pancit bihon off a recipe blog, and none of the three turned out to need anything exotic, just combinations I had never put together.

Adobo was the one that surprised me. I browned the chicken (*Gallus gallus domesticus*) first, then let it simmer for close to forty minutes in soy sauce, the cane vinegar, crushed garlic (*Allium sativum*), black peppercorns, and the bay leaves. I expected the vinegar to stay sharp the way it does in a quick pickle, but it mellowed as it cooked down, leaving a sauce that was salty and tangy without ever tasting sour. The technique itself felt familiar, slow-simmering meat in a covered pot is exactly what my family does for *tencere yemekleri*, but the acid doing the work was different. Turkish versions lean on tomato paste, peppers, or yogurt; here, vinegar and soy sauce did the job tomato paste usually does, breaking the meat down and building the sauce at the same time.

That contrast turned out to have real history behind it. Adobo predates Spanish contact: it developed as an indigenous method of preserving meat in vinegar and salt, and Spanish colonizers gave it a foreign name only after finding Filipinos already using it, a claim recent enough that a Spanish culinary historian presented the supporting archival evidence himself at a

2019 lecture at Ateneo de Manila University (Esquiremag.ph 2019). The pancit bihon had a similarly layered history. The word "pancit" comes from the Hokkien phrase pian e sit, "something conveniently cooked," and the dish traces to Chinese traders who introduced noodles to the islands, sold originally by vendors called panciteros out of stalls that functioned as the country's first fast food (Pepper.ph 2026). Stir-frying the noodles with cabbage (*Brassica oleracea*), carrots (*Daucus carota*), and more chicken and soy sauce, I noticed the noodles absorbed the sauce without turning heavy, closer to a dry pilaf than the wetter stir-fries I'd had before. The garlic rice, made from day-old rice (*Oryza sativa*) fried hard with garlic, needed no research at all; reusing leftover rice for the next meal is common sense in nearly every rice-eating household, mine included.

What struck me most wasn't unfamiliarity. It was recognizing the same basic architecture, meat, acid, rice, a slow pot, solved with a different acid and a different history behind every ingredient.

Works Cited

- Esquiremag.ph. 2019. "Filipinos Were Eating Adobo Before the Spaniards Came, Says Spanish Culinary Scientist." April 10. <https://www.esquiremag.ph/long-reads/history-of-adobo-a2017-20190410-lfrm>.
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